



NCL Spring 2026 Team Game Scouting Report

Dear Nathan Kuechler (Team "SANS.edu Accidental Threat Actors"),

Thank you for participating in the National Cyber League (NCL) Spring 2026 Season! Our goal is to prepare the next generation of cybersecurity professionals, and your participation is helping achieve that goal.

The NCL was founded in May 2011 to provide an ongoing virtual training ground for collegiate students to develop, practice, and validate their cybersecurity skills in preparation for further learning, industry certifications, and career readiness. The NCL scenario-based challenges were designed around performance-based exam objectives of CompTIA certifications and are aligned to the National Initiative for Cybersecurity Education (NICE) Cybersecurity Workforce Framework published by the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST).

As you look to a future career in cybersecurity, we hope you find this report to be valuable in both validating skills and identifying areas for improvement across the nine NCL skills categories. You can use this NCL Scouting Report to:

- Validate your skills to employers in any job application or professional portfolio;
- Show case your achievements and strengths by including the Score Card view of your performance as part of your résumé or simply sharing the validation link so that others may view the detailed version of this report.

The NCL Spring 2026 Season had 7,520 students/players and 583 faculty/coaches from more than 440 two- and four-year schools & 220 high schools across all 50 U.S. states registered to play. The Individual Game Capture the Flag (CTF) event took place from April 10 through April 12. The Team Game CTF event took place from April 24 through April 26. The games were conducted in real-time for students across the country. You were in the Experienced Students Bracket, consisting of students enrolled in advanced degrees or hold extensive industry working experience.

NCL is powered by Cyber Skyline's cloud-based skills evaluation platform. Cyber Skyline hosted the scenario-driven cybersecurity challenges for players to compete and track their progress in real-time.



To validate this report, please access: cyberskyline.com/report/9A5BFH0KYTKA

Congratulations for your participation in the NCL Spring 2026 Team Game! We hope you will continue to develop your knowledge and skills and make meaningful contributions as part of the Information Security workforce!

Dr. David Zeichick
NCL Commissioner



**EXPERIENCED
STUDENTS RANK
45TH PLACE
OUT OF 341
PERCENTILE
87TH**

NATIONAL CYBER LEAGUE SCORE CARD

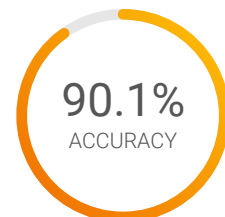
NCL SPRING 2026 TEAM GAME

YOUR TOP CATEGORIES

OPEN SOURCE
INTELLIGENCE
97TH PERCENTILE

PASSWORD
CRACKING
95TH PERCENTILE

NETWORK TRAFFIC
ANALYSIS
95TH PERCENTILE



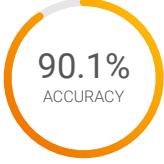
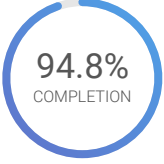
Average: 71.7%

cyberskyline.com/report/9A5BFH0KYTKA



NCL Spring 2026 Team Game

The NCL Team Game is designed for student players nationwide to compete in realtime in the categories listed below. The Team Game promotes camaraderie and evaluates the collective technical cybersecurity skills of the team members.

45TH PLACE OUT OF 341 EXPERIENCED STUDENTS RANK	2745 POINTS OUT OF 3000 PERFORMANCE SCORE Average: 1942.6 Points	 90.1% ACCURACY Average: 71.7%	 94.8% COMPLETION Average: 68.8%
87th Experienced Students Percentile			
Cryptography Identify techniques used to encrypt or obfuscate messages and leverage tools to extract the plaintext.	300 POINTS OUT OF 360	100.0% ACCURACY	COMPLETION: 92.9% 
Enumeration & Exploitation Identify actionable exploits and vulnerabilities and use them to bypass the security measures in code and compiled binaries.	260 POINTS OUT OF 300	93.3% ACCURACY	COMPLETION: 93.3% 
Forensics Utilize the proper tools and techniques to analyze, process, recover, and/or investigate digital evidence in a computer-related incident.	220 POINTS OUT OF 300	80.0% ACCURACY	COMPLETION: 70.6% 
Log Analysis Utilize the proper tools and techniques to establish a baseline for normal operation and identify malicious activities using log files from various services.	300 POINTS OUT OF 300	62.5% ACCURACY	COMPLETION: 100.0% 
Network Traffic Analysis Identify malicious and benign network traffic to demonstrate an understanding of potential security breaches.	300 POINTS OUT OF 300	100.0% ACCURACY	COMPLETION: 100.0% 
Open Source Intelligence Utilize publicly available information such as search engines, public repositories, social media, and more to gain in-depth knowledge on a topic or target.	370 POINTS OUT OF 385	95.7% ACCURACY	COMPLETION: 97.8% 
Password Cracking Identify types of password hashes and apply various techniques to efficiently determine plaintext passwords.	355 POINTS OUT OF 355	96.3% ACCURACY	COMPLETION: 100.0% 
Scanning & Reconnaissance Identify and use the proper tools to gain intelligence about a target including its services and potential vulnerabilities.	300 POINTS OUT OF 300	100.0% ACCURACY	COMPLETION: 100.0% 
Web Application Exploitation Identify actionable exploits and vulnerabilities and use them to bypass the security measures in online services.	240 POINTS OUT OF 300	93.8% ACCURACY	COMPLETION: 88.2% 

Note: Survey module (100 points) was excluded from this report.



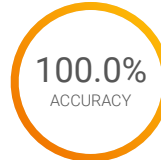


Cryptography Module

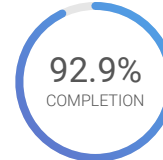
Identify techniques used to encrypt or obfuscate messages and leverage tools to extract the plaintext.

42 ND PLACE
OUT OF 341
EXPERIENCED STUDENTS RANK

300 POINTS
OUT OF 360
PERFORMANCE SCORE



Average: 72.3%



Average: 72.6%

88th Experienced Students
Percentile

Average: 230.1 Points

Paper Chase (Easy)

30 POINTS
OUT OF 30

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Manually extract a flag from an image of a punch card.

Hex password (Easy)

60 POINTS
OUT OF 60

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Recover a password that has been XOR-encrypted and encoded in UTF-16.

Decoding (Easy)

60 POINTS
OUT OF 60

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Identify and decrypt different cipher schemes.

Unc's Encryption (Medium)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Exploit poor implementation of ECDSA signatures through r value reuse.

Collisions (Medium)

50 POINTS
OUT OF 50

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Forge a message that produces a truncated SHA1 hash collision.

Checkpoint (Hard)

0 POINTS
OUT OF 60

0.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **0.0%**

Flip bits in AES-CBC ciphertext to forge a trusted session token.



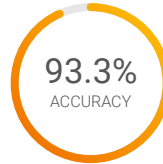


Enumeration & Exploitation Module

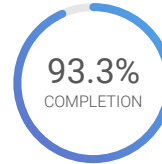
Identify actionable exploits and vulnerabilities and use them to bypass the security measures in code and compiled binaries.

68TH PLACE
OUT OF 341
EXPERIENCED STUDENTS RANK

260 POINTS
OUT OF 300
PERFORMANCE SCORE



Average: 80.1%



Average: 76.2%

81st Experienced Students
Percentile

Average: 217.9 Points

Getting into the Router (Easy)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Decompile a compiled python library and fix the bugs in it to retrieve the correct password.

Casserole (Medium)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Craft and execute a shellcode with NOP sleds in order to exploit a binary.

Malware Sample (Hard)

60 POINTS
OUT OF 100

80.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **80.0%**

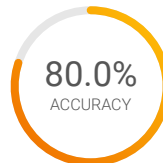
Chain a buffer overflow with a use-after-free vulnerability to bypass a software MTE simulator protecting a DGA botnet client.

Forensics Module

Utilize the proper tools and techniques to analyze, process, recover, and/or investigate digital evidence in a computer-related incident.

78TH PLACE
OUT OF 341
EXPERIENCED STUDENTS RANK

220 POINTS
OUT OF 300
PERFORMANCE SCORE



Average: 61.2%



Average: 70.5%

78th Experienced Students
Percentile

Average: 212.1 Points

Parallel (Easy)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Carve out recursive file embedding in images and files using file signatures.

In Plain Sight (Medium)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

83.3%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Identify IoCs and extract a zip file using hex carving from an RTF document.

Reg Recon (Hard)

20 POINTS
OUT OF 100

50.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **28.6%**

Identify Indicators of Compromise in Windows registry.



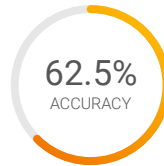


Log Analysis Module

Utilize the proper tools and techniques to establish a baseline for normal operation and identify malicious activities using log files from various services.

34TH PLACE
OUT OF 341
EXPERIENCED STUDENTS RANK

300 POINTS
OUT OF 300
PERFORMANCE SCORE



Average: 67.6%



Average: 77.5%

91ST Experienced Students
Percentile

Average: 220.1 Points

Unwelcome Robots (Easy)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Parse Apache combined log format access logs to identify a threat actor.

Falling Off a Log (Medium)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Extract information from a common Linux log format.

Survival Bias (Hard)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

33.3%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

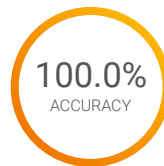
Process and cross reference json logs and provided intelligence to synthesize key information.

Network Traffic Analysis Module

Identify malicious and benign network traffic to demonstrate an understanding of potential security breaches.

20TH PLACE
OUT OF 341
EXPERIENCED STUDENTS RANK

300 POINTS
OUT OF 300
PERFORMANCE SCORE



Average: 74.8%



Average: 79.1%

95TH Experienced Students
Percentile

Average: 238.8 Points

WitSec (Easy)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Extract an image from HTTP network traffic.

Crafty Communique (Medium)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Extract information about players and chat messages from Minecraft server packets.

What is on the LAN? (Hard)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Find specific devices and traffic types on a network from a packet capture.



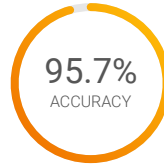


Open Source Intelligence Module

Utilize publicly available information such as search engines, public repositories, social media, and more to gain in-depth knowledge on a topic or target.

11TH PLACE
OUT OF 341
EXPERIENCED STUDENTS RANK

370 POINTS
OUT OF 385
PERFORMANCE SCORE



Average: 70.9%



Average: 76.7%

97th Experienced Students
Percentile

Average: 274.3 Points

Rules of Conduct (Easy)

45 POINTS
OUT OF 45

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Introductory challenge on acceptable conduct during NCL.

MEROPS (Easy)

50 POINTS
OUT OF 50

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Identify key search terms and execute search for information.

ATT&CKED (Easy)

75 POINTS
OUT OF 75

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Research and distill threat reporting to map adversary Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures (TTPs) to the MITRE ATT&CK framework.

Boarding Pass (Medium)

90 POINTS
OUT OF 90

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Decode a boarding pass barcode and use historical ADS-B data to discover information about a flight.

This Way Pleaaee! (Medium)

35 POINTS
OUT OF 50

75.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **75.0%**

Interpret coded messages to uncover a targeted operation.

Tracking the Tracker (Hard)

75 POINTS
OUT OF 75

87.5%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Cross reference Kismet GPS/WiFi/BLE logs with publicly available data.



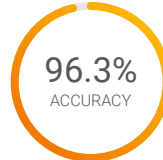


Password Cracking Module

Identify types of password hashes and apply various techniques to efficiently determine plaintext passwords.

18TH PLACE
OUT OF 341
EXPERIENCED STUDENTS RANK

355 POINTS
OUT OF 355
PERFORMANCE SCORE



Average: 81.1%



Average: 77.7%

95th Experienced Students
Percentile

Average: 252.7 Points

ID Me (Easy)

40 POINTS
OUT OF 40

80.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Identify MD5, SHA256, bcrypt, and JWT strings.

Bitcoin Hashes (Easy)

45 POINTS
OUT OF 45

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Generate random strings and hash them until the output contains the requested characters.

Lightly Seasoned (Easy)

40 POINTS
OUT OF 40

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Use a known plaintext attack to extract a user's password from a database of hashed passwords.

2-Ways (Medium)

50 POINTS
OUT OF 50

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Crack wireless passwords from packet captures using aircrack-ng and hashcat.

l33t p45\$vv0rc1z (Medium)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Perform a wordlist attack by generating possible candidates from known behaviors.

Unlocking 2 (Hard)

80 POINTS
OUT OF 80

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Generate BitLocker recovery key wordlists, crack the key, and decrypt the drive.



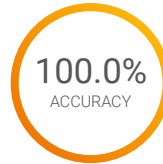


Scanning & Reconnaissance Module

Identify and use the proper tools to gain intelligence about a target including its services and potential vulnerabilities.

28TH PLACE
OUT OF 341
EXPERIENCED STUDENTS RANK

300 POINTS
OUT OF 300
PERFORMANCE SCORE



Average: 83.9%



Average: 78.4%

92ND Experienced Students
Percentile

Average: 232.8 Points

PrinT Farm (Easy)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Scan a target to identify vulnerable services and extract information.

Off Topic (Medium)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Scan an IoT network and subscribe to MQTT topics to identify IoTs.

AppScan (Hard)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

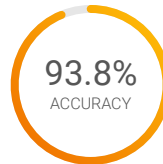
Analyze Static Application Security Testing tool outputs and develop a rule to improve vulnerability detection.

Web Application Exploitation Module

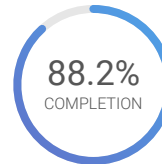
Identify actionable exploits and vulnerabilities and use them to bypass the security measures in online services.

48TH PLACE
OUT OF 341
EXPERIENCED STUDENTS RANK

240 POINTS
OUT OF 300
PERFORMANCE SCORE



Average: 67.9%



Average: 67.1%

86TH Experienced Students
Percentile

Average: 187.5 Points

Pairs (Easy)

80 POINTS
OUT OF 80

75.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Identify sensitive data stored in HTML attributes.

Stylish (Medium)

100 POINTS
OUT OF 100

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **100.0%**

Discover and validate a LESS.js Server Side Template Injection (SSTI) vulnerability.

Modern Tech Stack (Hard)

60 POINTS
OUT OF 120

100.0%
ACCURACY

COMPLETION: **77.8%**

Exfiltrate secrets using three advanced web vulnerability classes: type confusion, mutation XSS, and web cache deception.

